of all peoples of free world in great struggle between freedom and slavery but do not believe he was particularly impressed.[18]

Yet Bonsal continued trying to impress upon the Cubans the importance of private enterprise and foreign investment. In a July 23rd meeting Bonsal tried to impress upon Cuba's Minister of State that "many American private interests in Cuba have made great contributions to the country's economy in the agricultural field; many of our sugar and cattle enterprises have created employment and wealth where previously there was neither population nor production. These companies are entitled to considerate treatment … I referred also to the public utilities companies and to the importance of finding an arrangement which will permit these companies to continue to obtain the capital which they must have in order to meet the requirements of the expanding Cuban economy."[19]

But even Bonsal understood that U.S. economic control in Latin America had not necessarily been beneficial to the people there. "The Castro regime seems to have sprung from a deep and wide-spread dissatisfaction with social and economic conditions as they have been heretofore in Cuba and to respond to an overwhelming demand for change and reform," he wrote. "The universal support it has received from the humble and the lower middle classes is a witness to the strength of this compulsion … If we turn our back on them we risk pushing them into the arms of the Communists."[20]

Also worrisome, the popularity of the Cuban Revolution and its redistributive economic reforms might encourage other Latin American countries to challenge U.S. political and economic domination. A State Department official explained that "there are indications that if the Cuban revolution is successful, other countries in Latin America and perhaps elsewhere will use it as a model. We should decide if we wish to have the Cuban Revolution succeed."[21] Other U.S. officials concurred with this continental assessment. At the end of 1959 Assistant Secretary of State Roy Rubottom warned that "our attitude to date [could] be considered a sign of weakness and thus give encouragement to communist-nationalist elements elsewhere in Latin America who are